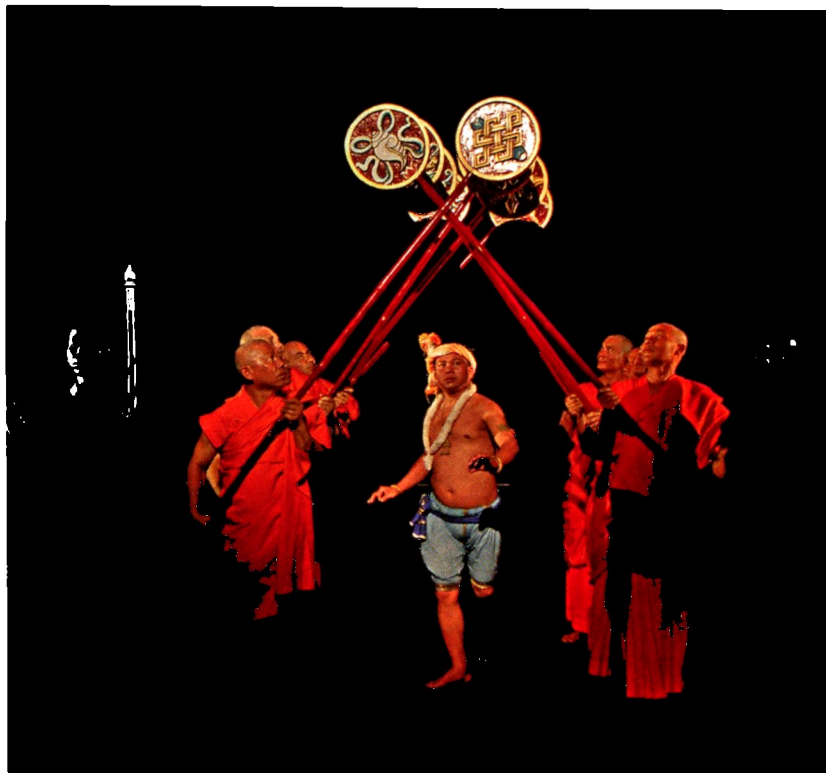




tural diplomacy to 33 Chinese cities and China will reciprocate with a Festival of China in India next month. Ironically, the India-China diplomatic relationship began on All Fools' Day in 1950, when New Delhi became the first non-socialist country to recognise Mao's China. It is hard-nosed pragmatism that is stirring their teapot today. The neighbours cannot afford to ignore each other. New Delhi is also invoking the historical legacy to remind China that they can be global bedfellows.

In Beijing, both sides have agreed to invoke what they call the spirit of Copenhagen, where India rallied with China to oppose any emission cuts that impeded growth. "It was a meeting of minds on bilateral, global and regional issues. It saw the emergence of new ideas and stronger engagement," said Jaishankar. They have also agreed to cooperate on Afghanistan where they have a shared stake in stability, considering both China and India are worried by growing Islamic extremism. Still, Beijing is not willing to let go of its old strategic pen-drive Pakistan that easily. And when Krishna raised the issue of

SIGNS OF A THAW

- An agreement to begin a hotline between the prime ministers of the two countries has been signed.
- President Pratibha Patil is slated to visit Beijing in May and a boundary dialogue is expected soon.
- China responds favourably to India's suggestion of the two foreign ministers' meeting annually.
- India and China to cooperate on Afghanistan, where both have a stake in its stability.
- New Delhi wants Beijing to work on its infrastructure projects in return of allowing the entry of Indian pharmaceutical and IT companies into China.

stapled visa and Chinese construction projects in the Pakistan-occupied Kashmir with his counterpart Yang, the Chinese chose to be ambivalent.

India too made its stand clear. The choice of the foreign minister's gift for his Chinese interlocutors were intricately hand-painted Kashmiri papier mâché boxes, a symbolic reminder that Jammu and Kashmir is an integral part of India. Nevertheless, New Delhi wants China to work in India in infrastructure projects in return for allowing the entry of Indian pharmaceuticals and Information Technology (IT) companies into China.

Both the countries today see trade as a unifier. Bilateral trade has touched \$43 billion and the target is \$60 billion in 2010. China has assured that it will work to reduce the trade deficit. Strategic analysts believe that it is time for both countries to stop squabbling on petty issues and leverage their common strengths. "Strategically it is important for China to engage with India and for China to engage with India. The Indian foreign minister's visit has helped to correct the perceptions between the two countries. They should shed old misconceptions that two tigers cannot coexist or two strong countries cannot live together," says Sun Shihai, a professor at Chinese Academy of Social Sciences.

Now that the two countries have a shared interest in keeping the spirit of Beijing alive, they have to move beyond the ghost of 1962. They would have to keep difficult issues in the closet as they work to restore trust in their relationship. India has shown that it wants a friendly relationship with Beijing. Now China has to reciprocate. The UPA leadership would have to use its informal leverage to reduce the trust deficit. Congress President Sonia Gandhi, accompanied by Rahul Gandhi, visited China twice in 2008. The Chinese are keen to expand such informal contacts. In the end, something as complex as the boundary dispute cannot be resolved without the highest level of political commitment—and intervention. Now that there is a hotline between Delhi and Beijing, both sides should make the best use of it. ■